OPENING UP the OPENNESS of JOINT ATTENTION

Lucas Battich

Faculty of Philosophy & Philosophy of Science, LMU Munich - Graduate School of Systemic Neuroscience, LMU Munich
Cognition, Values and Behaviour Research Group - Lucas.Battich@campus.lmu.de

INTRODUCTION

- **Joint attention** refers to two or more individuals coordinate their attention to a third object or event
- It is considered fundamental for *language learning*, for *understanding others* and for *joint actions*[1]
- It is often defined as a ***mutually open***, ***mutually manifest***, or ***transparent*** relation between co-attenders[2,3,4]

How should we characterize the openness of joint attention?

PROPOSAL

- Tensions in current approaches arise from the attempt to address *both* NORMATIVE and COGNITIVE questions

TWO EXPLANANDA

1. NORMATIVE How does joint attention rationally support joint beliefs and joint actions, and yields shared knowledge of our environment?
2. COGNITIVE What mental processes and understanding is involved in joint attention, which even infants and young children may be capable of having?

WHAT IS OPENNESS?

OPENNESS

Situation S is open between A and B when …

EPISTEMIC ⟷ **EXPERIENTIAL**

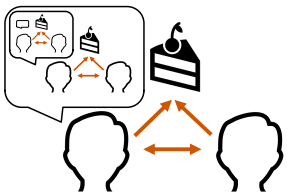
… S is epistemically shared between A and B

… S is fully present to the consciousness of A and B

PARADIGMATIC APPROACHES

REDUCTIVE APPROACH

- Epistemic openness can be explained in terms of the mental states of each co-attender
- Potentially infinite iteration of epistemic states[5]



NON-REDUCTIVE APPROACH

- There is a *primitive* intersubjective relation behind joint attention, which cannot be analyzed any further

John Campbell[2]
- Joint attention is a primitive type of conscious state

Naomi Eilan[3]
- Experiences of "You-awareness" or "Communication-as-connection" are primitive conscious states

TRADITIONAL CRITICISMS

- Requires recursive mindreading
- Intellectually demanding
- Psychologically implausible[2,6]

- Simply embeds in the analysis of openness or mutual awareness the property which is to be explained, i.e. the openness of joint attention[4]

RESOLUTION

Focus exclusively on the NORMATIVE question

- Iterations are logical implications, not mental processes
- The openness of joint attention is purely a normative notion
- There is nothing psychological about it

Upshot: give up the COGNITIVE explanandum

Focus exclusively on the NORMATIVE question

- The openness of joint attention is merely a description of phenomenal aspects of experience
- Being primitive, these aspects cannot be further explained

Upshot: give up the COGNITIVE explanandum

WHY DO WE NEED A NOTION OF OPENNESS?

- It is the key to tackle the NORMATIVE question
- It satisfies pre-theoretical intuitions on what it is like to engage in joint attention
  - → Does this apply to joint attention involving infants or non-human animals?
- It differentiates joint attention from related phenomena
  - → Openness assumes symmetry between co-attenders. Is this plausible?

CONCLUSION & HIGHLIGHTS

- Tensions in characterizing the openness of joint attention arise due to confounding explananda
- Keep distinct NORMATIVE questions from COGNITIVE questions
- If we are interested in the COGNITIVE question, there is no strong reason to assume apriori that the key feature of joint attention is its epistemic or experiential openness

[1] Mundy, P. (2018). A review of joint attention and social-cognitive brain systems in typical development and autism spectrum disorder. *Eur J Neurosci*, *47*(6).
[2] Campbell, J. (2018). Joint Attention. In Jankovic & Ludwig (Eds.), *The Routledge Handbook of Collective Intentionality*. New York: Routledge.
[3] Eilan, N. (2015). Joint Attention and the Second Person (draft).
[4] Peacocke, C. (2005). Joint Attention: Its Nature, Reflexivity, and Relation to Common Knowledge. In Eilan et al. (Eds.), *Joint Attention*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
[5] Lewis, D. (1969). *Convention*. Cambridge MA: Harvard University Press.
[6] Eilan, N. (2005). Joint Attention, Communication, and Mind. In Eilan et al. (Eds.), *Joint Attention*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.